ANNE BOYER

GARMENTS AGAINST WOMEN

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AT LEAST TWO TYPES OF PEOPLE

There are at least two types of people, the first for whom the ordinary worldliness is easy. The regular social routines and material cares are nothing too external to them and easily absorbed. They are not alien from the creation and maintenance of the world, and the world does not treat them as alien. And also, from them, the efforts toward the world, and to them, the fulfillment of the world's moderate desires, flow. They are effortless at eating, moving, arranging their arms as they sit or stand, being hired, being paid, cleaning up, spending, playing, mating. They are in an ease and comfort. The world is for the world and for them.

Then there are those over whom the events and opportunities of the everyday world wash over. There is rarely, in this second type, any easy kind of absorption. There is only a visible evidence of having been made of a different substance, one that repels. Also, from them, it is almost impossible to give to the world what it will welcome or reward. For how does this second type hold their arms? Across their chest? Behind their back? And how do they find food to eat and then prepare this food? And how do they receive a check or endorse it? And what also of the difficulties of love or being loved, its expansiveness, the way it is used for markets and indentured moods?

And what is this second substance? And how does it come to have as one of its qualities the resistance of the world as it is? And also, what is the person made of the second substance? Is this a human or more or less than one? Where is the true impermeable community of the second human whose arms do not easily arrange themselves and for whom the salaries and weddings and garages do not come?

These are, perhaps, not two sorts of persons, but two kinds of fortune. The first is soft and regular. The second is a baffled kind, and magnetic only to the second substance, and made itself out of a different, second, substance, and having, at its end, a second, and almost blank-faced, reward.

SEWING

Having given up literature, it was easy to become fixed on the idea of a single shirt, one with two pieces, no facings, not even set-in sleeves.

What can be done? How can two flat pieces joined together in four places accommodate a grown woman's torso, not at all flat, and with arms often in motion? It's just the same thing over and over, like when I used to listen to music, always stuck on a track, just this time in flannel, that time in linen, so many double pointed darts around the waistline cinching it in (Platonic ideal).

Every morning I wake up with a renewed commitment to learning to be what I am not. This is the day in which I will sew a straight seam, cut a piece of fabric precisely, follow the directions written by the pattern maker: stay stitch, clip notches. I will not presume to know more than the experts. I will always iron. No more jumping ahead, rebellion, daydreaming.

Each morning here is that sting of self-doubt, the chances of a wearable garment slim.

There are a lot of sleepless nights over seam finishes. In the heat of things, full of passionate expectation, I do things abruptly, crudely, mowing down the right-side-together $\frac{5}{8}$", eager to see what is flat turn into what has shape. Then regret—with a little planning, that could have been a French seam, or something better, exotic or sturdy or spectacularly imitative of ready-to-wear. The sewing book says the quality of one's seam is really the measure of one's character. That gets repeated a lot. That's bad news. I think of some future for the garment, inspected in the thrift store where it will someday rest: *this was not an attentive sewist,* the future shopper thinks, and wrinkles her nose or whatever, shrugs. It's me always praying no one will ever look at the inside of my blue skirt. To never leave evidence of excitement (someday, soon, finally).

At the Salvation Army I bought a gray silk polka-dotted wrap dress made a very long time ago by a woman named Louise Jones. She sewed a "fashioned by Louise Jones" label inside the neck of it. She gave it fine French seams. I bought that dress for four dollars along with a wide gold belt to wear with it for one dollar. The dress smells like lotion, or rather like old lotion and the smell of a body which must be the odor of the extraordinary seamstress Louise Jones.

It's really not better to imitate ready-to-wear. Louise Jones seemed to know this. People who don't sew don't know this. My daughter brings me some knitwear: *but can you do that*? She's pointing to a double-stitched finishing. Yeah, I say, I have double needle, but that doesn't mean I want to use it, not now. There's also that problem of people who think things are always better if done by machine. I mean, so did I, so guilty, really, thinking badly of hand-picked zippers. I could spend a year learning to do well what I have spent twenty years doing badly, and after that year, I could still be bad at what I do.

One of the inventors of the sewing machine didn't patent it because of the way it would restructure labor. Another was almost killed by a mob.

Always when I sew I think of Emma Goldman with her sewing machine, or Emma Goldman during her first night in jail "at least bring me some sewing." Wikipedia says the sewing machine reduced average garment construction time from 14 hours to 2 hours. Somewhere on a sewing blog someone wrote of making new garments from existing ones: "use every part of the garment" and "each garment holds in it hours of a garment worker's life." I sew and the historical of sewing becomes a feeling just as when I used to be a poet, when I used to write poetry, used to write poetry and that thing—culture—began tendriling out in me, but it is probably more meaningful to sew a dress than to write a poem. I make anywhere from 10 to 15 dollars an hour at any of my three jobs. A garment from Target or Forever 21 costs 10 to 30 dollars. A garment from a thrift store costs somewhere between 4 and 10 dollars. A garment at a garage sale costs 1 to 5 dollars. A garment from a department store costs 30 to 500 dollars. All of these have been made, for the most part, from hours of women and children's lives. Now I give the hours of my life I don't sell to my employers to the garments. My costs are low: 2-dollar fabric from Goodwill, patterns bought for 99 cents or less, notions found at estate sales for 1 or 3 dollars. I almost save money like this. The fabric still contains the hours of the lives, those of the farmers and shepherds and chemists and factory workers and truckers and salespeople and the first purchasers, the givers-away, who were probably women who sewed. Sewing is difficult. There is a reason girls were trained in it before they were trained in anything else, years and years spent at practice, and even then they might not have been any good.

Sometimes when you look at smoothly joining at least two different-sized pieces of flat but pliable material so that these pieces might correctly encase an eternally irregular, perspiring and breathing three-dimensional object that cannot cease its motion you think that there is no way ever this could happen, yet sometimes it does.

Even heroic refusals often aren't that heroic though some are more heroic than others.

The best garment made out of a scarf is the skirt made of two scarves one of the sex workers wears in *Le Notti di Cabiria*. She's the angry one who is getting older who has the hard face and hard bangs shouting at Cabiria that Cabiria, too, will get old and beg someday. Cabiria only really gets pissed off and stops dancing at the mention of Giorgio. This sex worker has, like many of the sex workers in the movie, garments and accessories made of the pelts of animals or made of fibers that resemble these pelts. Cabiria herself often looks like a drowned cat in her fur or fur-like jacket. I not so long ago found a rabbit-hair sweater printed in the pattern of a snake skin and bought at the same time to wear with it a leopard-printed belt.

I set in sleeves. Perfected the skirt. Made one bright blue cord A-line skirt, one brown twill narrow skirt, one blue narrow skirt (no yoke), one brown linen top with dolman sleeves and three mother-of-pearl buttons, one brown twill top with a black yoke, one black wrap top from a vintage pattern. Learned the key to everything was not the time spent on the machine but the time spent with a needle in hand.

I'm okay with subjectivity. It's silky wovens that mess me up. I put everything back in its place, thinking I ought to be sewing less and writing more. Everyday I have a list called "Everyday."

It's only necessary to make a transparent account if it's necessary to have accounting, and it's only necessary to have accounting in the service of a profitable outcome. To account in the service of profit is to assume the desirability of profit. The individual doing the accounting is, like who or what she serves, also assumed to be in the service of profit, as profit is assumed to be desirable, and if she is in the service of profit, it's assumed she would like to profit also, and that what she would do if there were no transparency is cause herself to profit.

Without an open book, she would, following her assumed desire, steal, so that she makes a transparent account is always first in some service of that larger body that is the order of business. If she makes a transparent account, she may or should profit in one only one way: to benefit, as a reward for service to the order of business, and from the profitability of the larger body, and benefit, likewise, from behaving as a small replication of the order of business herself.

She is accounting transparently because there is a larger body which claims to know her heart: it assumes her heart is naturally a heart desiring profit, a heart which reflects (in miniature) the fundamental desire of the larger body, too. Or perhaps this is her heart or perhaps she has been convinced that to keep a clear and open record will be to be her benefit. Or, if she is not convinced this is to her benefit, she has been convinced she has no choice but to act in accord. She has been convinced that this is what one does when one has nothing to hide.

Yet this is not "nothing to hide": it is "something to show"—a performance, for the order of business, that her desires are in accord with its,

that she would so naturally desire profit as to want to steal it and therefore, her "something to show" is the naturalness of the larger body's desires.

The accounting is also the transparency required, by convention, among humans in human relationships like children to their parents, of a husband to his wife, or a friend to a friend. It could be the transparent account of oneself and one's life required by those service jobs—so many—which require of their workers "the best intentions" and an "open heart." It could also be a "transparent account" that is literature.

If the books are muddled, confused, lost, damaged, inconsistent or otherwise opaque, the bookkeeper has provided a suspect record. She has probably stolen. Or maybe not. But the proof of her bad deed is in the presentation of opaqueness, and the heart's alignment with the one desire is, by the larger body, assumed. And maybe she has. To steal is to behave as a natural extension and reinforcement of a desire that everyone knows is what's real.

It's a requirement of the idea of the "transparent account" that someone should steal as an affirmation of the desirability of profit. It is like how marriage requires adultery, or journalism requires poets, or how the family requires that children will sometimes run away.

But maybe the person has thought about accounting, and thought about how it gives the wrong forms to desire insofar as the very act of it is to give reinforcement to a very limited one, has thought maybe there's a greater crime than embezzlement, and this is the refusal of accounting altogether. And what, this person asks, about how a transparent account

is not actually anything like veracity, how there is another veracity that includes conspiracy, corners, shadows, slantwise, evasion, unsayingness, negation, and under-the-beds?

She might just prefer to be neither bookkeeper nor embezzler finally, when desire with an audience becomes, like pornography, a desire about the audience's desires, and there is another desire: to keep one's desire for one's self and off the books.

To refuse a bookkeeperly transparency is to protect the multiplicity of what we really want. Like the body's books, like the public's records, literature is just left there, open, as if its openness, its transparency—the "anybodiness" of its reader—is anything like the truth. But in conspiracy, verity.

I offered his virus to the mechanized virus reader. It had many functions, among these the one that translated "virus" into "sick room architectures." Thus the design specs for his recovery: a 15′ × 15′ outdoor room with a perimeter of medium-height pines, inside of these pines a hospital bed and an eight-foot flat-screen TV.

"at first it appeared that she was weeping so that I might change my mind and buy the $44 shoes, but soon she was unable to stop weeping. she refused to try on other shoes in other stores even though the shoes she wore were too small and had recently been in a mud puddle. she could see how even not-the-best-shoes-ever not-the-shoes-that-looked-like-art would be better than dirty ill-fitting shoes, but she could not stop weeping. we walked through stores while she wept. we sat in the middle of the mall while she wept. we went to a discount store, and I told her I would just pick out shoes for her because she wept too much to try on shoes. she wept in the discount store. she wasn't weeping by design. she couldn't stop weeping, then she stopped weeping a little and we found some brown sneakers for $44 on clearance. in the car I wanted to weep, too, but she said to me 'I am still a child and am learning to control my impulses and emotions. you have had many years of dreams and realities to learn from so there is no excuse for you to cry.' she paused. 'do you have enough dreams?' she finally asked."

NOT WRITING

When I am not writing I am not writing a novel called *1994* about a young woman in an office park in a provincial town who has a job cutting and pasting time. I am not writing a novel called *Nero* about the world's richest art star in space. I am not writing a book called *Kansas City Spleen*. I am not writing a sequel to *Kansas City Spleen* called *Bitch's Maldoror*. I am not writing a book of political philosophy called *Questions for Poets*. I am not writing a scandalous memoir. I am not writing a pathetic memoir. I am not writing a memoir about poetry or love. I am not writing a memoir about poverty, debt collection, or bankruptcy. I am not writing about family court. I am not writing a memoir because memoirs are for property owners and not writing a memoir about prohibitions of memoirs.

When I am not writing a memoir I am also not writing any kind of poetry, not prose poems contemporary or otherwise, not poems made of fragments, not tightened and compressed poems, not loosened and conversational poems, not conceptual poems, not virtuosic poems employing many different types of euphonious devices, not poems with epiphanies and not poems without, not documentary poems about recent political moments, not poems heavy with allusions to critical theory and popular song.

I am not writing "Leaving the Atocha Station" by Anne Boyer and certainly not writing "Nadja" by Anne Boyer though would like to write "Debt" by Anne Boyer though am not writing also "The German Ideology" by Anne Boyer and not writing a screenplay called "Sparticists."

I am not writing an account of myself more miserable than Rousseau.
I am not writing an account of myself more innocent than Blake.

I am not writing epic poetry although I like what Milton said about lyric poets drinking wine while epic poets should drink water from a wooden bowl. I would like to drink wine from a wooden bowl or to drink water from an emptied bottle of wine.

I am not writing a book about shopping, which is a woman shopping.
I am not writing accounts of dreams, not my own or anyone else's.
I am not writing historical re-enactments of any durational literature.

I am not writing anything that anyone has requested of me or is waiting on, not a poetics essay or any other sort of essay, not a roundtable response, not interview responses, not writing prompts for younger writers, not my thoughts about critical theory or popular songs.

I am not writing a new constitution for the republic of no history.
I am not writing a will or a medical report.

I am not writing Facebook status updates. I am not writing thank-you notes or apologies. I am not writing conference papers. I am not writing book reviews. I am not writing blurbs.

I am not writing about contemporary art. I am not writing accounts of my travels. I am not writing reviews for *The New Inquiry* and not writing pieces for *Triple Canopy* and not writing anything for *Fence*. I am not writing a daily accounting of my reading, activities, and ideas. I am not writing science fiction novels about the problem of the idea of the autonomy of art and science fiction novels about the problem of a society with only one law which is consent. I am not writing stories based on

Nathaniel Hawthorne's unwritten story ideas. I am not writing online dating profiles. I am not writing anonymous communiqués. I am not writing textbooks.

I am not writing a history of these times or of past times or of any future times and not even the history of these visions which are with me all day and all of the night.

There are years, days, hours, minutes, weeks, moments, and other measures of time spent in the production of "not writing." Not writing is working, and when not working at paid work working at unpaid work like caring for others, and when not at unpaid work like caring, caring also for a human body, and when not caring for a human body many hours, weeks, years, and other measures of time spent caring for the mind in a way like reading or learning and when not reading and learning also making things (like garments, food, plants, artworks, decorative items) and when not reading and learning and working and making and caring and worrying also politics, and when not politics also the kind of medication which is consumption, of sex mostly or drunkenness, cigarettes, drugs, passionate love affairs, cultural products, the internet also, then time spent staring into space that is not a screen, also all the time spent driving, particularly here where it is very long to get anywhere, and then to work and back, to take her to school and back, too.

There is illness and injury which has produced a great deal of not writing. There is cynicism, disappointment, political outrage, heartbreak, resentment, and realistic thinking which has produced a great deal of not writing. There is reproduction which has been like illness and injury and taken up many hours with not writing. There is being anxious or depressed which takes up many hours though not very much once there is no belief in mental health. There is trauma which is fantastic in the way it is brief and clear and also the way it lingers around and emerges unpredictably as if it will forever. Trauma is always the indirect direct producer of so much not writing. It is like a mind which has a shadow and then is the shadow and then isn't a mind or its shadow but isn't at all.

There are some hours, though not very many, on airplanes, and times with friends spent in the production of not writing. There is talking which is like writing and which produces not writing in equal measure to producing writing. There is an amount of time not writing which is not wanting to actually have to talk to humans unless it is in order to get them to have sex or in order to convince them to leave. There is sleep, which is often dreams, which is closer to writing—dreams are more like writing than not writing in that they are not intruded upon in their moments by the necessities of all the paid work, care work, social expectations, romantic love or talking to people. There is sleep which is often about gossip, architecture, and modes of civic planning and in this is closer to writing than not writing. In the dreams there is always walking around, finding walls, follies, and not getting to one place or the next but it is often those I love but whom I do not get to see very much who walk with me. There are photographs one takes, of oneself and of other people and it is in these there is the production of not writing. There is dressing and undressing, sometimes too much, particularly when things have run away, died, or one has to meet new people. There is shopping, which is a woman shopping.

There is in not writing not very much time spent on envy which is a pang, mostly, which is motivating like getting a buzz from an outlet telling one to remove one's hand from the outlet, from the power source. There is the way that the lives of others seem so often unenviable and only enviable as they are "writing" when all this time is spent not writing like right now in the not writing in which I should be dealing with bills, mail, laundry, my bedroom, months of emails from October onward even though it is now June, with my jobs, with care, with the contents of my refrigerator, with my flat tire, with the cat's litter box, with friendship,

with Facebook, with my body which wants to get in the swimming pool with my body which wants to turn brown in the sun with my body which wants to drink some tea with my body which wants to do shoulder presses which wants to join a gym which wants to take a shower and get cleaned up which wants a lover which mostly wants to swim and then there is "not writing." There is envy which is also mixed with repulsion at those who do not have a long list of not writing to do.

It is easy to imagine not writing, both accidentally and intentionally. It is easy because there have been years and months and days I have thought the way to live was not writing have known what writing consisted of and have thought "I do not want to do that" and "writing steals from my loved ones" and "writing steals from my life and gives me nothing but pain and worry and what I can't have" or "writing steals from my already empty bank account" or "writing gives me ideas I do not need or want" or "writing is the manufacture of impossible desire" or writing is like literature is like the world of monsters is the production of culture is I hate culture is the world of wealthy women and of men.

A WOMAN SHOPPING

I will soon write a long, sad book called *A Woman Shopping*. It will be a book about what we are required to do and also a book about what we are hated for doing. It will be a book about envy and a book about barely visible things. This book would be a book also about the history of literature and literature's uses against women, also against literature and for it, also against shopping and for it. The flâneur is a poet is an agent free of purses, but a woman is not a woman without a strap over her shoulder or a clutch in her hand.

The back matter of the book will only say this: *If a woman has no purse, we will imagine one for her.*

These would be the chapters:

On a woman shopping
On men shopping, with and without women
On children with women as they shop
On the barely moving lips of the calculating and poor
On attempting to open doors for the elderly and in the process of this, touching their arms
On the acquiring of arms in action movies
On Daniel Defoe
On the time I saw a homeless man murdered for shoplifting
On whether it is better to want nothing or steal everything
On how many of my hours are gone now because I have had to shop
On how I wish I could shop for hours instead

There would be more: lavish descriptions of lavish descriptions of the perverse or decadently feminized marketplace, some long sentences concerning the shipping and distribution of alterity, an entire chapter about *Tender Buttons* in which each sentence is only a question. And from where did that mutton, that roast beef, that carafe come?

But who would publish this book and who, also, would shop for it? And how could it be literature if it is not coyly against literature, but sincerely against it, as it is also against ourselves?

I will leave no memoir, just a bitch's *Maldoror*. There's a man. He tells me he does not like the version of the story in which he is like Simon Legree who ties me down to the railroad tracks. This is because he is like Simon Legree who ties me down to the railroad tracks. He is the man who looks at the blue sky and says "Do not remember this blue sky as blue."

I look with my eyes at the blue sky and see that it is blue, then also I look with my eyes at him and make a note to not remember the blue sky as blue. I make a note, also, to remember the proclamation, by him, against the color of the sky. I make a note, also, that I will have known the sky was blue, then I will have been told to forget what I know about the sky and probably did. I make a note to doubt the legibility of any of these notes for these are notes about people who together believe a human sentence—one spoken by a man and heard by a woman—can commute the blueness of the sky itself.

That I would walk outside each day and see a blue sky would mean whatever. That so many years I have seen blue skies does not make the blue sky on that day blue.

There's an equal, independent truth that exists along with the sky itself: this is what he says against it. In this, he is like some other men: commanding. The sky can exist as a knowable color. But the commands of such men are equally persistent and knowable, too.

Despite the reality of the sky, that it is blue, a woman with any interior is trumped by a man with any exterior. Or that is what I read in the notes: even the color of the sky is stable only as long as it has a man's proof.